Pollution and speculation

Instead, it is worth dwelling on the two most widely recognised problems of our time, as the most recent Pew global public opinion survey (Pew Research Global Attitudes Project 2013) confirms: climate change and systemic global financial instability. In both, the BRICS suffer what in psychology is termed 'co-dependency'. The word 'comes directly out of Alcoholics Anonymous, part of a dawning realisation that the problem was not solely the addict, but also the family and friends who constitute a network for the alcoholic', according to Lennard Davis (2008). The BRICS are friendly-family *enablers* of Western capitalists, who are fatally addicted to speculative-centric, carbon-intensive accumulation. The most fatal long-term Western obsession facilitated by the BRICS is the emission of greenhouse gases at whatever level maximises corporate profits, future generations be damned to burn. In November 2014, this was confirmed when Barack Obama and Xi Jinping agreed to continue carbon emissions at a level that will lock in a 4 degree temperature rise. In contrast, recall the last time the world's 1% seriously kicked the pollution habit – and genuinely, albeit momentarily, succeeded with what is termed global governance – which was in 1987. With the Montreal Protocol, CFCs were banned so as to halt ozone hole expansion. But since that successful cold turkey episode, neoliberal and neoconservative fetishes took hold. Half-hearted efforts at the UN and other multilaterals to address global-scale environmental, economic and geopolitical disasters have conspicuously failed.

That addiction is just one of the Western afflictions which the BRICS enable. Undeniably, self-destructive financial/monetary policy is another. Suffering what increasingly appears to be the neurological impairment of a junkie, officials in Washington, London, Brussels, Frankfurt and Tokyo continue helter-skelter pumping of zero-interest dollars, euros and yen into the world economy, mainly feeding asset bubbles. This is a hopeless drug-addict's fix: maintaining policies of economic liberalisation that lower national economic barriers and generate huge gains for already wealthy elites holding property or stock market shares. BRICS elites are *not* enemies of the Western economic hedonists, as revealed in the 2014 Fortaleza Declaration (VI BRICS Summit 2014a), which provided exceedingly gentle advice to the West: 'Monetary policy settings in some advanced economies may bring renewed stress and volatility to financial markets and changes in monetary stance need to be carefully calibrated and clearly communicated in order to minimise negative spillovers.' (This refers to currency crashes suffered by most BRICS when the West began reducing 'Quantitative Easing' money-printing in May 2013 – yet another example of co-dependency.)